

Art deco

Derived from such diverse influences as African, Aztec, ancient Egyptian, futurism and cubism, art deco manifested in most fields of design. Taking its name from the International Exposition of Modern Decorative and Industrial Arts, held in Paris in 1925, where the style was first exhibited, art deco was modern and opulent, and its geometric motifs contrasted sharply with the fluid signatures of art nouveau. Buildings are often embellished with hard-edged, low-relief designs in stepped patterns, chevrons and sunburst patterns; prominent materials include chrome, glass, lacquer and inlaid wood. The style endured throughout the Depression because it was practical, clean-cut and optimistic. Epitomizing the machine age, it appeared in streamline moderne designs (see [here](#)) including New York's Chrysler Building (opposite, 1928–30 designed by William Van Alen (1883–1954) and the Empire State Building (1930) designed by William F. Lamb (1893–1952). In New Zealand, the coastal town of Napier, devastated by the 1931 earthquake, was largely rebuilt in the art deco style.

